

average engineering college. That is unfortunately skewing us towards too many engineers in the management programmes.” According to Amit Agnihotri, Founder of think-tank the MBAUniverse.com, the exam fails to capture “soft skills like EQ, creativity, interpersonal skills, etc., which are all the more important for people heading teams across the corporate world”.

Then, CAT hands out percentile scores, instead of an absolute score, which isn't doing any good. Because of this, “the B-school does not know anything about the candidates' individual competencies, but knows only where they stand within the pool of candidates”, says Sachin Jain, Country Manager of ETS, a testing agency that conducts GRE and TOEFL.

The test also lacks flexibility. Krishna Pathak, Co-founder of health-tech company Oyoga, who took both CAT and GMAT tests in 2019, and later went on to do his MBA from Harvard Business School, says, “The CAT exam runs on its own schedule, and catching up with it is often dif-

Asia and China is viewed with suspicion, giving India an opportunity to become a management hub in this part of the world.

VYING FOR THE CROWN

The first step towards an international ranking is to jump on to the accreditation bandwagon, say the colleges. The Triple Crown in management education refers to business schools certified by three major bodies: The Association to Advance Collegiate Schools of Business (AACSB), the Association of MBAs (AMBA), and EFMD Quality Improvement System (EQUIS). And getting them is a pitted process. “Accreditation is not an affair to be taken lightly. It involves some investment of time, money, resources, etc., and the agencies will not give you accreditation that easily. It takes several years and sometimes multiple attempts to get accredited,” says IIMB Director Rishikesh T. Krishnan.

Only 24 participants of BT's ranking of two-year programmes in India have at least one international accreditation. Within these, only IIMC and IIMI are triple-crown holders (as is ISB, which tops BT's new ranking for one-year MBAs). Eighteen institutes have AACSE, 11 have AMBA and only four have EQUIS—IIMC, IIMI, IIMA, and IIMB (IIM Kozhikode, which did not participate in BT's ranking, also has EQUIS accreditation).

The schools point out that some of the consideration criteria such as internationalisation, research output in international publications, and carbon footprint & sustainability are inherently disadvantageous for India. “These rankings are based on certain parameters which we don't want to fulfil because we don't want to lose our character. Diversity in inter-country students is one of the parameters in those rankings. We have 95-98 per cent Indians,” says IIMA Director Bharat Bhasker.

EQUIS, particularly, requires the schools to attract international students. The definition of international has hurt Asian schools a fair bit, say heads of institutes. “A minor school in Luxembourg will get ranked higher because it is no big deal for someone from Spain or Germany to go there. It's a totally unfair way of defining what ‘international’ means,” says Nagaraj. Besides, salaries of students and faculty in India will be lower than what a European economy offers, even if considered at purchasing power parity, the SPJIMR Dean adds.

Sangeeta Shah Bhardwaj, Acting Director of MDI Gurgaon, says that large B-schools with a good corpus, processes, and batch size can show their performance required to attain global ranking, while smaller B-schools possibly find it harder. “When smaller stand-alone and privately funded B-schools are struggling

The CAT exam has evolved over the years but it has not received global recognition like a GMAT

ficult. Also, the exam scores are valid only for one academic year, unlike GMAT where one can take the test whenever they want, stash it, and go out to improve their profile, gain more experience, etc.”

Chanchal Kushwaha, Chairperson of Admissions at Birla Institute of Management Technology (BIMTECH), says some of the issues can be resolved if the test setters don't change annually.

Colleges in India have realised that CAT alone cannot be the best judge of a candidate's competencies. Because of this, over 20 MBA entrance tests have surfaced, like XAT by Xavier School of Management, NMAT by NMIMS University, SNAP by Symbiosis International (Deemed) University, CMAT and IIFT by National Testing Agency, etc.

That is only queering the pitch for students who have to appear for a multitude of tests to get into an MBA programme in a good institute. Clearly, it is time to rethink the framework of MBA admissions in India. **BT**